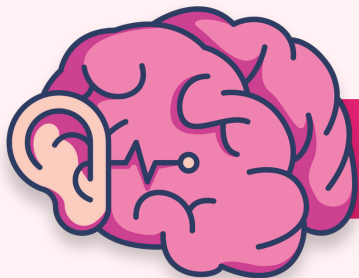


The Ultimate Shadowing Guide



From passive listening



to active speaking!



Speak with confidence: boost your pronunciation, fluency and vocabulary all through one simple technique.

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Introduction: What Is Shadowing and Why Should You Do It?

Shadowing is a simple but powerful technique for improving your English pronunciation, rhythm and fluency. It involves listening to an English speaker and repeating what they say — at the same time or just a moment after — like an **echo**. It might feel a little odd at first, but with regular practice, it can make a real difference to how natural and confident you sound.

When you shadow correctly, you're **training your brain and mouth to work together** more quickly. You're not only improving your accent and clarity—you're also learning how English sounds in real life: the tone, the flow and the little linking sounds that often get missed in textbooks.

How to Use This Guide

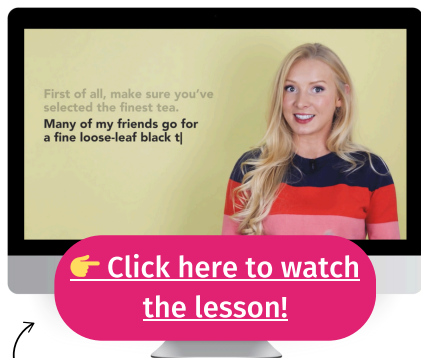
This document is your companion for a fully guided shadowing session. You'll follow each step of a natural, everyday script — in this case, making the perfect cup of tea — with pronunciation help and speaking tips at each stage.

Here's what you'll find inside:

- **Targeted shadowing tips** to help you copy natural pronunciation, stress and intonation
- **Pronunciation analysis** after each part of the script, so you know what to focus on
- **A vocabulary bank** at the end of the guide, with definitions and examples of key words and phrases

You can use this guide while watching the video lesson or practise with the script on its own. Either way, take your time, pause when you need to, and don't worry if it feels tricky at first—it means your brain is working hard in all the right ways.

Let's get started!



Click here to watch the video!

For the best results, follow along with the video that goes with this guide. Hearing the natural rhythm and pronunciation will help you shadow more effectively.

Use the YouTube controls to:

- **Slow down the speed**
- **Pause and repeat**
- **Rewind tricky parts**

Go at your own pace and focus on clear, accurate speech.

Before: The Preparation Ceremony

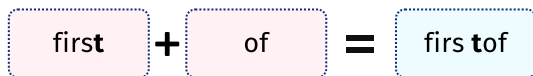
Get ready to speak along with me. If you're practising in a public space, don't worry! You can just silently mouth the words and then have another go in the privacy of your own home!

Firstof all, make sure you've selected the finest tea. Many **/j/** of my friends go for **/r/** a fine loose-leaf black tea, but for me, nothing beats a traditional English Breakfast blend in a bag. Then, it's time to select your drinking vessel. I know what you're thinking - the moment has come to whip out granny's finest bone china. Although that works for some, I personally prefer a novelty mug. Making tea should make you smile - and what's guaranteed to bring a smile to your face? That mug with your pet's face on it! Next, we select the **f**reshest **f**iltered water and **f**ill the kettle. Never **/r/** ever reboil water, as it removes oxygen and **will** likely ruin your perfect brew. The final stage of preparation - and this is the one my mother taught me **not** to skip - we need to heat the mug. That's right, pour **/r/** a little of your freshly boiled water into your chosen mug, give it a little swirl and pour **/r/** it out. And before you **/w/** ask, no, you may not boil the water in the microwave. That would be unforgivable.

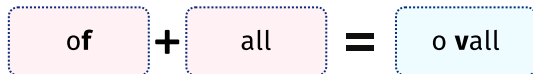
Pronunciation Analysis

Let's take a look at some of the key pronunciation features in this text. Then, you can repeat this section before moving on to the next.

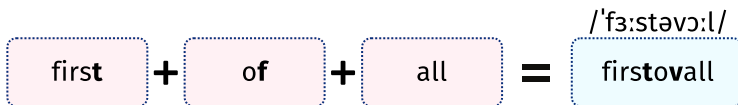
Did you notice how **'first of all'** sounded like one word? That's because we take the consonant sound /t/ at the end of 'first' and **join it to the following vowel sound** /ə/.



We do the same with 'of' - take the /v/ sound and **attach it to 'all'**.



This consonant-to-vowel linking helps us to avoid unnecessary gaps between words.



Yes, I agree - it does sound similar to the word **'festival'**! /'festɪvəl/. There are more examples here too, like **fay so nit** (face on it).

A **plosive** is a sound we make by stopping the airflow for a moment and then releasing it suddenly.

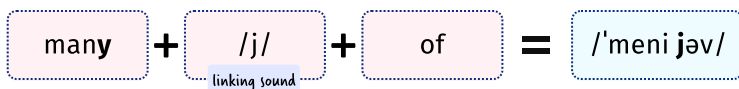
In English, the plosive sounds are /p/, /b/, /t/, /d/, /k/ and /g/.

Moving on. Did you notice what I did when I said **'finest tea'**? Here we have two identical consonant sounds together. /t/ is a **plosive** sound. When we have two identical plosive

sounds together, we don't need to repeat the sound twice. Instead, just get ready to make the first sound, hold a tiny bit longer than usual and then release.

The same happens with **'not to skip'**. With some consonant sounds, we don't need to pause at all - we just make the consonant sound longer, for example, **'will likely'**. Notice how I didn't repeat the /l/ sound, I just lengthen it slightly.

Then, we have a **linking /j/** sound between **many /j/ of** /'meni jəv/. Notice the weak form there too - I said /'meni jəv/ not /'meni jɒv/. We can add a soft /j/ after words ending in /i:/ vowel sounds when they're followed by another vowel sound.



One distinctive feature of my Modern RP accent is that **I only pronounce the letter 'r' when it comes before a vowel sound**. This is true in individual words and also in connected speech. So, in this sentence here -

Many of my friends go for a fine loose-leaf black tea, but for me, nothing beats a traditional English Breakfast blend in a bag.

I only make a **/r/ sound** before the vowel sound /ə/. Listen and compare. I've highlighted the other linking /r/ sounds in the text on page 4.

Let me draw your attention to another interesting feature here. When I read this phrase **'what you're thinking'** - something interesting happened. When **/t/** and **/j/** sounds are next to each other like this, we often combine them to make a new **'ch'** sound - /tʃ/. So, instead of saying 'What. You.', we can blend the sounds and make a 'ch' sound. **Whatcha /'wɒtʃə/**

Why? Well, it's more efficient, and we're all about saving energy when we speak!

Now read this line: **"freshest filtered water and fill the kettle."**

Notice anything?

We've got a cluster of words starting with the same sound — **f**reshest, **f**iltered, **f**ill. This is called **alliteration**.

It's when a sound, usually at the beginning of words, repeats to create rhythm or emphasis. In this case, the repeated **/f/** sound gives the phrase a pleasing flow — and helps it stick in your mind. It's like a little melody made of consonants, which is why this pronunciation is so common in branding and advertising:

- **Coca-Cola**
- **Dunkin' Donuts**
- **PayPal**
- **Range Rover**

During: When The Magic Happens

Ok, let's move on to the next stage of our tea-making process. You ready to read along with me again?

Carefully drop your teabag into your mug. We can't afford to let **that** freshly boiled water cool, so pour it straight into **the** mug and **then** gently stir. Do not—and I really can't stress **this** strongly **/j/** enough—add your milk before you add **the** water. Yuck! Now **/w/** is **the** time to step back and allow **the** magic to happen. I wait for precisely **three** minutes and **thirty** seconds—just enough time to lay out my favourite biscuits, chocolate digestives, and admire **the** golden hue beginning to form. Feel free to stir your tea a couple more times, but whatever you do, don't squeeze **that** teabag against **the** side of **the** mug! We do not want a bitter cuppa! When **the** time is up, lift **that** tea bag out ever so gently and pop it in **the** compost. **Then**, we add a splash of cold—**that's** right, cold milk until we get **the** perfect shade of gold. Remember—you can always add milk, but you can't take it away! Patience and precision are your friends. Should **you** add sugar? I'm personally against it, but you might need to **/w/** ask guests if **they** want one lump or two.

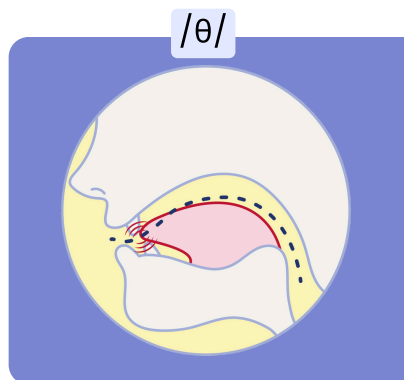
Pronunciation Analysis

Let's examine some more interesting pronunciation features from the second section.

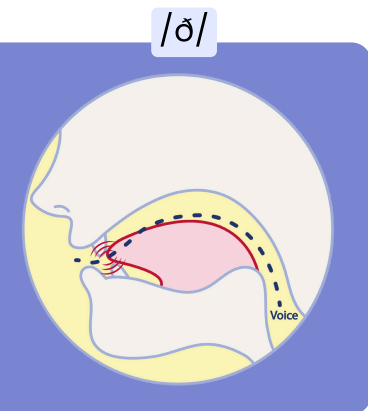
The **TH** sounds, like we have in these words

- **three**
- **thirty**

can be particularly difficult for many learners of English. One way to make sure you're pronouncing them accurately is to poke the tip of your tongue out of your mouth slightly. As you breathe out, air travels through the gap between your tongue and top teeth.



If you keep your tongue inside your mouth and touch the top of your mouth, you will probably make a **/t/** sound instead. **Three** and **thirty** are made with the unvoiced sound **/θ/**.

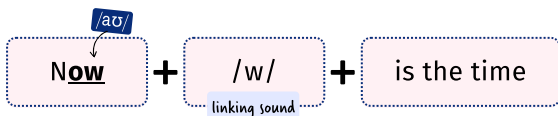


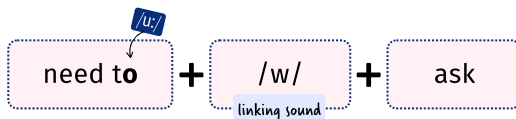
Other **TH** words like 'that', 'the' and 'then' are made with the voiced **/ð/**, so you should feel some vibration. It tickles a bit, actually!

Again, if you keep your tongue inside your mouth you might say **dat**, **de** and **den** instead.

So, check your tongue position and don't forget to add vibration.

Next we have another **linking sound** - **/w/**. We can add a soft **/w/** to join rounded vowel sounds like **/aʊ/** and **/u:/** to another vowel sound. For example:





Did you notice how I dropped the **/t/** sound in the negative contractions ‘**can’t stress**’, ‘**don’t squeeze**’ and ‘**can’t take**’? This often happens when we have a **/t/** sound between consonant sounds. You don’t have to drop this **/t/** sound, but it can make speaking easier, faster and more fluid.

We also have another example of two sounds coming together to form a new sound.

- Should you → /'ʃudʒu:/

The **/d/** and **/j/** combine to make **/dʒ/**, so instead of saying ' /ʃud ju:/, we say /'ʃudʒu:/.

After: The Enjoyment

Ok, are you ready for the final stage?

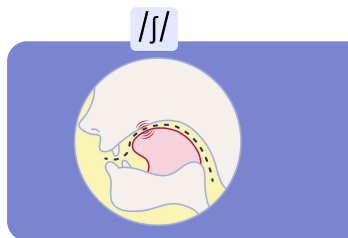
Now **/w/** I know you’ve been **patient**, but it’s **essential** we don’t rush this final stage. We sip, not slurp, as we **breathe** in the **warmth** and comfort of the perfect cuppa. Contrary to popular belief, we do not stick out our pinky finger. Quite the **/j/** opposite. On **cold days** especially, we gently hug the mug and heat up our freezing fingers. After a few small sips, you’ll feel the **/j/** anticipation growing as the culmination of all your hard work and dedication draws near. This is the moment we’ve all been waiting for. It’s time to dunk the digestive. Here, timing is key. If you’re overcautious, the biscuit will still be hard, and the chocolate **won’t’ve** melted. Leave it too long, and the biscuit will dissolve and sink to the bottom of the mug. Practice makes perfect!

Pronunciation Analysis

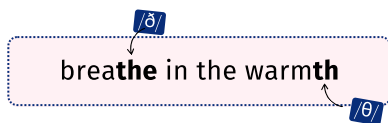
Did you use a **soft /w/** to join '**now** /w/ I'?



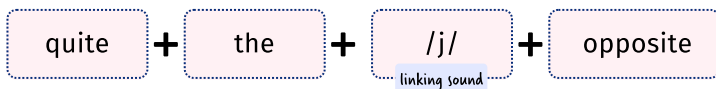
Did you pronounce the lovely '**sh**' sound in '**patient**' /'peɪʃnt/ and '**essential**' /ɪ'senʃl/? Just like you're telling someone to be quiet - politely, of course!



We've got those tricky **TH** sounds again here too - we switch between the voiced and unvoiced:

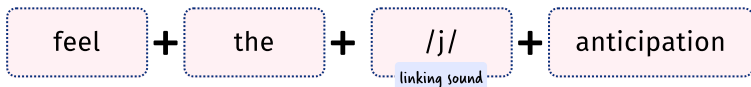


Did you also spot the **linking /j/** in the phrase:



We also had more consonant linking with '**on cold days**' - remember, hold then release: cold **days**.

We have another **linking /j/** -



And then last, but certainly not least, one of my absolute favourite pronunciation features - a **double contraction**!

- will not have → **won't've** /'wəʊntəv/

Vocabulary Bank



[Click here to access the vocabulary bank!](#)

Click the link above to open the **Interactive Vocabulary Bank** for this lesson. Tap each 'info' button to see the definition, part of speech and an example sentence.